

CSS Text-Decoration

Complete Guide: Lines, Colors, and Styles for Text

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1 Introduction

The CSS `text-decoration` property family controls decorative lines applied to text. These properties enable developers to add visual emphasis and styling to text elements with underlines, overlines, line-throughs, and wavy lines.

1.1 Text-Decoration Properties

The text-decoration family includes:

- **text-decoration-line:** Type of line (underline, overline, line-through)
- **text-decoration-color:** Color of the line
- **text-decoration-style:** Style of the line (solid, dotted, dashed, wavy, double)
- **text-decoration-thickness:** Thickness of the line
- **text-decoration-skip-ink:** Whether to skip descenders
- **text-decoration:** Shorthand property

1.2 Historical Context

Early text decoration was limited to underlines on links. Modern CSS provides extensive customization for professional and creative text styling.

2 text-decoration-line

The `text-decoration-line` property specifies which type of decorative line to apply.

2.1 Available Line Types

Value	Description	Use Case
<code>none</code>	No decoration	Remove default styles
<code>underline</code>	Line below text	Links, emphasis
<code>overline</code>	Line above text	Headers, citations
<code>line-through</code>	Line through text	Strikethrough, discounts
<code>blink</code>	Blinking text	Deprecated, don't use

2.2 Single Line Decoration

```
/* Underline */
a {
  text-decoration-line: underline;
}

/* Overline */
.citation {
  text-decoration-line: overline;
}

/* Line-through */
.discount {
  text-decoration-line: line-through;
}

/* No decoration */
a {
  text-decoration-line: none;
}
```

2.3 Multiple Lines

Combine multiple decoration lines:

```
/* Underline and overline */
.emphasized {
  text-decoration-line: underline overline;
}

/* All three lines */
.highly-decorated {
  text-decoration-line: underline overline line-through;
}

/* Flexible combination */
.custom {
  text-decoration-line: overline line-through;
```

```
}
```

3 text-decoration-color

The `text-decoration-color` property sets the color of the decorative line.

3.1 Color Values

```
/* Named colors */
a {
  text-decoration-color: red;
}

/* Hex colors */
a:hover {
  text-decoration-color: #3498db;
}

/* RGB colors */
.link {
  text-decoration-color: rgb(52, 152, 219);
}

/* RGBA with transparency */
.transparent-decoration {
  text-decoration-color: rgba(0, 0, 0, 0.5);
}

/* HSL colors */
.hsl-decoration {
  text-decoration-color: hsl(200, 100%, 50%);
}

/* CSS variables */
:root {
  --decoration-color: #3498db;
}

a {
  text-decoration-color: var(--decoration-color);
}
```

3.2 Color Combinations

```
/* Different from text color */
a {
  color: #333;
  text-decoration-color: #e11d48;
}
```

```

/* Gradient effect (visual) */
a {
  color: blue;
  text-decoration-color: red;
  text-decoration-line: underline;
}

/* Transparent decoration */
.subtle {
  color: black;
  text-decoration-color: rgba(0, 0, 0, 0.3);
  text-decoration-line: underline;
}

/* Matching text color */
a {
  color: inherit;
  text-decoration-color: currentColor;
  text-decoration-line: underline;
}

```

4 text-decoration-style

The `text-decoration-style` property controls the visual style of the decorative line.

4.1 Decoration Styles

Style	Description	Visual
<code>solid</code>	Continuous line	
<code>double</code>	Two lines	
<code>dotted</code>	Dotted line	
<code>dashed</code>	Dashed line	
<code>wavy</code>	Wavy line	

4.2 Decoration Style Examples

```

/* Solid underline (default) */
a {
  text-decoration-style: solid;
}

/* Dotted underline */
.spelling-error {
  text-decoration-line: underline;
  text-decoration-style: dotted;
  text-decoration-color: red;
}

/* Dashed line-through */
.old-price {
  text-decoration-line: line-through;
}

```

```
    text-decoration-style: dashed;
}

/* Wavy underline */
.grammar-error {
    text-decoration-style: wavy;
    text-decoration-color: orange;
}

/* Double overline */
.citation {
    text-decoration-line: overline;
    text-decoration-style: double;
}

/* Combining styles */
a:hover {
    text-decoration-line: underline;
    text-decoration-style: wavy;
    text-decoration-color: blue;
}
```

5 text-decoration-thickness

The `text-decoration-thickness` property controls the thickness of the decorative line.

5.1 Thickness Values

Type	Examples
Pixel units	1px, 2px, 3px
EM units	0.05em, 0.1em
Keywords	auto, from-font

5.2 Thickness Examples

```
/* Thin underline */
a {
  text-decoration-line: underline;
  text-decoration-thickness: 1px;
}

/* Standard thickness */
a {
  text-decoration-thickness: 2px;
}

/* Thick decoration */
.emphasized {
  text-decoration-thickness: 3px;
}

/* EM-based thickness */
p {
  text-decoration-thickness: 0.1em;
}

/* Auto thickness (browser default) */
a {
  text-decoration-thickness: auto;
}

/* From font metrics */
a {
  text-decoration-thickness: from-font;
}

/* Proportional */
.fine-print {
  font-size: 12px;
  text-decoration-thickness: 1px;
}

.headline {
  font-size: 32px;
  text-decoration-thickness: 3px;
}
```


}

6 text-decoration-skip-ink

The `text-decoration-skip-ink` property controls whether decorative lines skip over descenders (parts of letters like g, p, y that extend below the baseline).

6.1 Skip-Ink Values

Value	Behavior
<code>auto</code>	Skip descenders (default)
<code>none</code>	Don't skip descenders
<code>all</code>	Skip all content

6.2 Skip-Ink Examples

```
/* Skip descenders (default) */
a {
  text-decoration-line: underline;
  text-decoration-skip-ink: auto;
}

/* Don't skip, line goes through descenders */
.continuous {
  text-decoration-skip-ink: none;
}

/* Skip all content */
.spaced {
  text-decoration-skip-ink: all;
}

/* Text with descenders: "apply", "playing", "goodbye" */
.link-with-descenders {
  text-decoration-line: underline;
  text-decoration-skip-ink: auto; /* Cleaner look */
}
```

7 The text-decoration Shorthand

The `text-decoration` shorthand combines all text-decoration properties.

7.1 Shorthand Syntax

```
text-decoration: [line] [color] [style] [thickness];
```

Order doesn't matter; all components are optional.

7.2 Shorthand Examples

```
/* All components */
a {
  text-decoration: underline blue wavy 2px;
}

/* Just line and color */
a {
  text-decoration: underline red;
}

/* Line and style */
.error {
  text-decoration: underline dotted;
}

/* Full specification */
.special {
  text-decoration: overline line-through solid green 3px;
}

/* Remove decoration */
a {
  text-decoration: none;
}

/* Shorthand with single value */
.underlined {
  text-decoration: underline;
}
```

8 Real-World Examples

8.1 Example 1: Professional Link Styling

```
/* Default link */
a {
  color: #0066cc;
  text-decoration: underline solid 1px;
  text-decoration-skip-ink: auto;
}

/* Hover state */
a:hover {
  color: #0052a3;
  text-decoration: underline solid 2px;
}

/* Visited state */
a:visited {
  color: #663399;
}
```

```
}

/* Focused state */
a:focus {
  outline: none;
  text-decoration: underline wavy #3498db 2px;
}

/* Active state */
a:active {
  text-decoration: underline solid 3px;
}
```

8.2 Example 2: Error and Warning Text

```
/* Spelling error */
.spelling-error {
  text-decoration: underline dotted red;
  text-decoration-thickness: 2px;
}

/* Grammar error */
.grammar-error {
  text-decoration: underline wavy orange;
}

/* Deprecated item */
.deprecated {
  text-decoration: line-through gray;
  text-decoration-thickness: 1px;
}

/* On-sale item */
.on-sale {
  text-decoration: line-through #999 1px;
}

/* New/updated indicator */
.updated {
  text-decoration: overline dotted #27ae60 2px;
}
```

8.3 Example 3: Blog Article Styling

```
article a {
  color: #0066cc;
  text-decoration: underline solid 1px;
  transition: all 0.2s ease;
}

article a:hover {
```

```
    color: #0052a3;
    text-decoration-thickness: 2px;
}

article .highlight {
    text-decoration: underline overline solid #f39c12 2px;
}

article .emphasis {
    text-decoration: underline wavy #3498db;
}

article .important {
    text-decoration: underline overline solid red 3px;
}

/* Internal vs external links */
a[href^="http"]::after {
    content: " ";
    text-decoration: none;
}

a:not([href^="http"]) {
    text-decoration: underline solid 1px;
}
```

8.4 Example 4: Interactive List Items

```
.list-item {
    padding: 10px;
    cursor: pointer;
    text-decoration: none;
    transition: all 0.2s ease;
}

.list-item:hover {
    background-color: #f0f0f0;
    text-decoration: underline solid #3498db 2px;
}

.list-item.completed {
    text-decoration: line-through solid #999 1px;
    color: #999;
}

.list-item.active {
    text-decoration: underline solid #e11d48 3px;
    background-color: #fff9fa;
}

.list-item.pending {
    text-decoration: dotted underline #f39c12 2px;
}
```

```
.list-item.new {  
  text-decoration: double underline #27ae60 2px;  
}
```

8.5 Example 5: Product Card with Pricing

```
.product-price {  
  font-size: 1.5rem;  
  color: #e11d48;  
}  
  
.original-price {  
  text-decoration: line-through solid #999 1px;  
  font-size: 1rem;  
  color: #999;  
}  
  
.discount-label {  
  text-decoration: underline overline solid #27ae60 2px;  
  font-weight: 600;  
}  
  
.on-sale {  
  text-decoration: dashed underline #f39c12 2px;  
}  
  
.best-seller {  
  text-decoration: double underline #ffc107 2px;  
}  
  
.limited-stock {  
  text-decoration: wavy underline red;  
  animation: pulse 2s infinite;  
}
```

9 Advanced Techniques

9.1 Animated Text Decoration

```
/* Animated underline */  
a {  
  position: relative;  
  text-decoration: none;  
  color: #333;  
  transition: color 0.3s ease;  
}  
  
a::after {  
  content: '';  
  position: absolute;
```

```
width: 0;
height: 2px;
bottom: -4px;
left: 0;
background-color: #3498db;
transition: width 0.3s ease;
}

a:hover::after {
width: 100%;
}

/* Animated color change */
a {
text-decoration: underline solid transparent 2px;
transition: text-decoration-color 0.3s ease;
}

a:hover {
text-decoration-color: #3498db;
}

/* Animated thickness */
a {
text-decoration-thickness: 1px;
transition: text-decoration-thickness 0.3s ease;
}

a:hover {
text-decoration-thickness: 3px;
}

/* Multi-animation */
a {
text-decoration: underline solid transparent 1px;
color: #333;
transition: all 0.3s ease;
}

a:hover {
color: #0066cc;
text-decoration-color: #0066cc;
text-decoration-thickness: 2px;
}
```

9.2 Custom Underline with Box-Decoration-Break

```
/* Multi-line underline */
p {
text-decoration: underline solid #3498db 2px;
box-decoration-break: clone; /* Decorate each line */
}
```

```
/* Continuous underline across lines */
p {
  text-decoration: underline;
  box-decoration-break: none;
}
```

10 Browser Support

10.1 Text-Decoration Properties Support

Property	Chrome	Firefox	Safari	Edge
text-decoration-line	26+	6+	6+	26+
text-decoration-color	57+	36+	12.1+	79+
text-decoration-style	57+	6+	12.1+	79+
text-decoration-thickness	89+	70+	12.1+	89+
text-decoration-skip-ink	64+	70+	15.1+	79+

10.2 Fallback Strategies

```
/* Provide fallback for older browsers */
a {
  /* Fallback for older browsers */
  text-decoration: underline;

  /* Modern browsers will use these */
  text-decoration: underline solid #3498db 2px;
  text-decoration-skip-ink: auto;
}

/* Feature detection with @supports */
@supports (text-decoration-thickness: 2px) {
  a {
    text-decoration: underline solid #3498db 2px;
  }
}

@supports not (text-decoration-thickness: 2px) {
  a {
    text-decoration: underline;
  }
}
```

11 Accessibility Considerations

11.1 Text Decoration and Accessibility

- **Contrast:** Ensure line color contrasts with background
- **Clarity:** Avoid excessive decoration that obscures text

- **Meaning:** Don't rely solely on decoration for meaning
- **Links:** Ensure links are distinguishable (color + style recommended)
- **Screen readers:** Decoration is visual; use aria labels if needed

11.2 Accessible Link Examples

```
/* Good: Multiple visual indicators */
a {
  color: #0066cc; /* Color difference */
  text-decoration: underline; /* Decoration */
}

a:hover,
a:focus {
  background-color: #e3f2fd; /* Additional feedback */
}

/* Bad: Only color indicates link */
a {
  color: #0066cc;
  text-decoration: none; /* No other indicator */
}

/* Good: Persistent underline */
a {
  text-decoration: underline solid 2px;
}

/* Good: Focus visible */
a:focus {
  outline: 3px solid #3498db;
  text-decoration: underline solid 3px;
}
```

12 Common Mistakes

12.1 Mistake 1: Removing Link Underlines Without Alternative

Bad:

```
a {
  text-decoration: none;
  /* No visual indicator it's a link */
}
```

Good:

```
a {
  color: #0066cc; /* Color indicates link */
  text-decoration: underline; /* Underline confirms it */
}
```



```
a:hover {  
  text-decoration: underline solid 2px;  
}
```

12.2 Mistake 2: Low Contrast Decoration

Bad:

```
a {  
  color: #999;  
  text-decoration: underline;  
  text-decoration-color: #ddd; /* Hard to see */  
}
```

Good:

```
a {  
  color: #0066cc;  
  text-decoration: underline solid blue; /* High contrast */  
}
```

12.3 Mistake 3: Confusion with text-decoration-line: blink

Bad:

```
.alert {  
  text-decoration: blink; /* Deprecated, don't use */  
}
```

Good:

```
.alert {  
  text-decoration: underline wavy red 2px;  
  animation: pulse 2s infinite; /* Use animation instead */  
}  
  
@keyframes pulse {  
  0%, 100% { opacity: 1; }  
  50% { opacity: 0.7; }  
}
```

13 Combining text-decoration with Other Properties

13.1 With Color Properties

```
a {  
  color: #0066cc;  
  text-decoration: underline;  
  text-decoration-color: #e11d48; /* Different colors */  
}
```

```
/* Using currentColor */
button {
  color: blue;
  text-decoration: underline;
  text-decoration-color: currentColor;
}

button:hover {
  color: darkblue; /* Decoration color changes too */
}
```

13.2 With Font Weight

```
/* Bold with decoration */
strong {
  font-weight: 700;
  text-decoration: underline solid #333 2px;
}

/* Different weight, different decoration */
a {
  font-weight: normal;
  text-decoration: underline 1px;
}

a:hover {
  font-weight: 600;
  text-decoration: underline 2px;
}
```

13.3 With Transitions

```
a {
  text-decoration: underline solid transparent 1px;
  transition: text-decoration-color 0.3s ease,
              text-decoration-thickness 0.3s ease;
}

a:hover {
  text-decoration-color: #3498db;
  text-decoration-thickness: 3px;
}
```

14 Summary: Key Takeaways

14.1 Text-Decoration Properties

Property	Purpose	Common Values
text-decoration-line	Line type	underline, overline, line-through
text-decoration-color	Line color	Any CSS color
text-decoration-style	Line style	solid, dotted, wavy, dashed, double
text-decoration-thickness	Line width	1px, 2px, 3px
text-decoration-skip-ink	Skip descenders	auto, none

14.2 Best Practices

1. Use underlines to indicate links
2. Ensure decoration color contrasts with background
3. Combine color with decoration for clarity
4. Test across browsers for consistent appearance
5. Don't use blink; use animations instead
6. Skip descenders for cleaner look (auto)
7. Use transitions for interactive effects
8. Provide focus indicators for accessibility
9. Test with screen readers when using decoration for meaning
10. Keep decoration subtle unless emphasizing

14.3 Quick Reference

```
/* Professional link styling */
a {
  color: #0066cc;
  text-decoration: underline solid 1px;
  text-decoration-skip-ink: auto;
}

a:hover {
  text-decoration-thickness: 2px;
}

a:focus {
  outline: none;
  text-decoration: underline wavy #3498db 2px;
}

/* Strikethrough with color */
.discount {
  text-decoration: line-through solid #999 1px;
```

```
}

/* Custom decoration combination */
.emphasized {
  text-decoration: underline overline solid #f39c12 2px;
}

/* Error indication */
.error {
  text-decoration: underline dotted red 2px;
}

/* Animated underline */
a {
  text-decoration: underline solid transparent 1px;
  transition: text-decoration-color 0.3s ease;
}

a:hover {
  text-decoration-color: #3498db;
}
```

15 Conclusion

CSS text-decoration properties provide fine-grained control over decorative lines applied to text. From professional link styling to creative visual effects, text-decoration enables developers to create engaging, accessible web experiences.

Key principles to remember:

1. Text-decoration-line defines the type of line
2. Color should contrast with background
3. Style choices affect readability and aesthetics
4. Thickness should match design system
5. Accessibility requires clear link indicators
6. Modern browsers support all properties well
7. Transitions enhance interactivity
8. Shorthand provides concise syntax
9. Test on various devices and browsers
10. Use sparingly for maximum impact

With mastery of text-decoration properties, you'll create professional, accessible, and visually appealing text styling that enhances user experience and guides user attention.

Happy coding!